officials' statements about the Vietnam War that irked US policymakers, Jha asked for American understanding. They stemmed, he told Kissinger, from the government's dependence on political support from left parties and the left wing of the Congress Party. More broadly, he reiterated that India's concern about US policy was not because Delhi was "pro-Chinese" or "pro-Soviet" but because it believed "the use of force may strengthen Chinese influence in the area."[128]

The Gandhi government also tempered its criticism. Officials like the Indian representative in Hanoi wanted Delhi to repudiate US policy even if it caused a "partial rupture" because otherwise a "timid" India was leaving the field to China.[129] But Delhi refused to do so. American officials noticed that the Indian reaction to US military operations in Cambodia was less harsh than expected, with Indian officials expressing "regret" but avoiding condemnation.[130] Haksar even suggested that Gandhi avoid a meeting with Nixon to steer clear of discussing the "uncomfortable" questions of Southeast Asia and the Middle East since "we would not wish to be unfriendly" to the US.[131] Realizing India could not stay silent on developments in Southeast Asia, Swaran Singh suggested to Jha that he should note Indian differences with the US but "without causing any annoyance."[132] Finally, India refrained from upgrading relations with the DRV, even as it did so with East Germany.[133]

But the US and Indian effort in 1970 to keep their relations on an even keel floundered in 1971 when a crisis broke out in East Pakistan.

Triangulation and the Tilts (1971)

In March 1971, the Pakistani military launched a crackdown in Bengali-majority East Pakistan (present day Bangladesh) on demonstrators demanding implementation of national election results and greater autonomy. The situation deteriorated over the next few months: the Pakistani leadership refused to yield; the Bengali-dominated Awami League (AL) party called for independence; refugees escaping the crackdown flowed into India; separatist guerrillas backed by Delhi commenced operations from India against the Pakistani military; China declared its support for Pakistan; and both India and Pakistan moved troops on high